We know much less about Chinese communities in India than we do about Indian communities in China. In 1871–72, there were about 1100 Chinese in Calcutta and Bombay. By the Second World War, though, the numbers had grown to 15,000.[26] The largest number were in Bengal, around Calcutta, and in parts of Assam. The first immigrant came to Bengal as early as 1778. He brought tea and got a land grant in return for setting up a sugar mill. He then imported Chinese labour. Added to this were 'runaway sailors and indentured servants'.[27] By the early nineteenth century, the Chinese had built community life in a residential area in Calcutta's Bowbazar. The immigrants were tradespeople – 'shoemakers, opium-sellers, carpenters, cabinet makers, and lard manufacturers'. By the end of the nineteenth century, their numbers had been fortified by new immigrants, and they established new businesses, associations, temples, and schools. In addition to carpentry and shoemaking, they set up tailor shops, tanneries, restaurants, tea stalls, dental clinics, pharmacies, grocery stores, and they sold silk and paper flowers.[28]

This suggests that Chinese immigrants led a reasonably productive and peaceful life in India. However, it was not all sweetness and light between the immigrants and host communities in Calcutta, Darjeeling, Kalimpong, and Assam. A nineteenth-century British official recorded that sections of the Chinese hated the local population 'in all intensity of Chinese hatred'. The Chinese apparently felt that they depended on British protection and that the colonials were 'better paymasters than the local Bengalis'. In his account of the community, Sen notes 'the preference to work for the British in India continued to be expressed by Chinese migrants up through Indian independence . . . indicating the uncomfortable existence of the ethnic Chinese among the Indians'. This would come back to haunt them in the late 1950s and early 1960s when India–China tensions sharpened.[29] Particularly from 1959, sections of the Chinese were spied on and eventually had to register with the police. Anyone who failed to do so lived under threat of deportation. According to the Chinese scholar Xing Zhang, bank accounts were 'confiscated', remittances to China halted, and 'Chinese shops were pillaged by mobs and forced to paste words against the Chinese